like a huge never-ending holiday, and every aspect of Maharashtra's culture was represented in those fourteen days.

As an artist, I am constantly looking to capture people's emotions—in their eyes and their actions. I tried doing that in my own way during the Yatra. But the point of mentioning this here is to suggest that I have long felt that a seasoned and mature political leader also must have that knack. And I believe Rahul Gandhi does. He would keenly observe people standing on the sides and invite them to join him. I remember that a group of about fifty children from Chhatra Bharati had come from Mumbai, Nashik and Ahmednagar to meet Rahul Gandhi. He not only heard them out while he walked, but also raised their issues the next day. Rahul did this multiple times during the Yatra. And when a leader becomes a conduit for the people's voices and issues, they keep flocking to him. I think to a large extent, this was what was happening. Word was spreading like wildfire that here was this one-shot opportunity to raise one's voice, so let's go. And so they just kept coming.

But while Rahul was the centre of the Yatra, he was also not. Each yatri was equally the centre of the Yatra. The yatris had their own interactions with people. Many of them were engaging and interacting with the festivities (for how else can one even describe what we were witnessing?) and the people. And some of them kept working while walking and talking with everyone. Many of us were astounded at how hard some of these young Congresspersons worked. I recall Pushparaj, Ruchira, Nagorao, Vikram, Varun, Hrishikesh and so many others, who worked like dynamos without losing their cool (while they interacted with people within and outside the Yatra). Only they know how they managed to juggle so much. Meanwhile, other yatris engaged newcomers like us in different ways. For example, Sitaram Lamba from Rajasthan would sing a new song every day. One such song was: 'We have come to the tune of the heart, we will not rest, we will embrace the heart.' These simple words touched the hearts of many listeners, who enthusiastically joined in. Similarly, Ajay Lallu (the former state president of Uttar Pradesh), who was also a yatri, would break into hilarious limericks to entertain us.